

Goibibo: Technology Evolution, the Open Source Way

Open source technology is definitely more mainstream than it was a few years back. Companies use it to gain an edge, rather than to just save money. Goibibo.com is one such example. **Diksha P Gupta** from **Open Source For You** caught up with **Vikalp Sahni, CTO, Goibibo.com**, when he attended Open Source India 2014 to showcase how open source proved to be a technological advantage for the organisation. Here, he shares his open source success story.



Vikalp Sahni, CTO, Goibibo.com

While we do know that virtually every organisation has been touched by open source technology in some way or the other, we thought of looking at firms that have made it really big while deploying open source technology. We did not have to look too hard. *Goibibo.com*, the popular online travel aggregator, made the job easier for us. Goibibo has one of the biggest deployments of open source technology and its tech team has set an example on how open source can be the best choice.

Open source addresses all tech challenges

Talking of his deployments at Goibibo.com, Vikalp Sahni, CTO, says, "Goibibo uses a variety of open source tools, right from the language we code in to our day-to-day data source and infrastructure needs. We build software using Python, and embrace open source frameworks like Django and Flask for Web applications. Besides, we use a lot of open source

libraries like gevents, fabric, etc, to scale our product. On the data sources front, we have a lot of SQL and NoSQL setups running on open source technologies, ranging from MySQL and Redis to various tools on the Hadoop ecosystem for data platforms. Overall, we are very open to embracing open source technology and always look at it as our first preference while trying to solve a technology problem."

Sahni is pretty clear as to why he chooses open source alternatives over the other 'hand-cuffed' proprietary choices. He says he embraces open source due to its 'on the technology curve' philosophy. Sahni vouches, "Open source not only saves you money but also exposes your software stack to the larger community, thus getting the benefit of multiple minds when it comes to scale. We have seen that our developers who work on open source technologies are always excited and motivated about being part of a large tech community where they get to contribute on a regular basis, whether it is open sourcing some library/code or submitting bug fixes.

"At times, proprietary software does help in quicker resolution of challenges because of the in-house expertise, but now, with the growing number of enthusiasts in the open source ecosystem and technology forums, this gap is narrowing pretty fast."

Unlike many enterprises that use open source technology only for back-end operations, Goibibo has gone a step further and made open source technology available at the user level too! The company uses front-end frameworks like Backbone, Underscore, etc, on the browser JavaScript side, which helps to take user interaction to the next level. In addition, on the mobile apps' (Android and iOS) side, there are libraries and tools that Goibibo uses to ensure an enhanced user experience.

Sahni, who firmly believes in open source technology and the philosophy behind it, claims that this technology addresses almost all the requirements of Goibibo. He asserts, "We are a technology-driven organisation and from the transaction engine to CRM systems, we have open source components in use. We use open source tools for automation and intelligence too. In pretty much all the business functions, we embrace open source technologies."